

Whose outcomes should government planning focus on - citizen's or government's outcomes?

When developing DoView strategy/outcomes diagrams it's important to be clear about whose outcomes are to be included - citizen's and/or government's. Different governments want to help different groups of citizens in different ways. One can identify at least four rationales for why governments assist citizens. Whether an initiative's outcomes should be determined just by citizens' needs, or by government's needs, or by a mix of both depends on which rationale is being used.

A first rationale for government assisting citizens is for things that people have a constitutional, statutory or widely accepted basic right to (e.g. voting, justice, defense). Under this rationale, citizens' rights heavily determine the outcomes that are specified. A second rationale is the provision of general services for all citizens (e.g. types of infrastructure, health, education, employment). Different governments will provide different amounts of these services depending on their particular political orientation. Outcomes under this rationale will be a mix of citizen-needs and what government sees it as a priority to provide.

A third rationale is that even where a government is not providing services for the whole population, it might provide specific assistance to some people whose life chances are less. This is on the basis that in a competitive society, everyone has the right to compete on a 'level playing field'. The outcomes for activity under this rationale are to meet citizens' needs but only within the envelope of outcomes for which government decides to attempt to ensure a level playing field (e.g. welfare, housing, health).

A fourth rationale for government assisting citizens is that it may seek to reduce tomorrow's expenditure that is likely to arise from people experiencing social problems today. The outcomes specified for this activity will be determined by citizens' needs but as with the third rationale, within the envelope of those needs that are most likely to create future social spending if not addressed now. See the Using Social Investment to Reduce Future Government Expenditure Explainer (E9) for more on this. Different governments will provide a mix of various services to a greater or lesser extent under each of these four rationales which will determine the scope of citizens' needs that will be included in the outcomes for government activity.

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